



Policing and Society

An International Journal of Research and Policy

ISSN: (Print) (Online) Journal homepage: <https://www.tandfonline.com/loi/gpas20>

Digitize and Punish: racial criminalization in the digital age

Brian Jefferson, Minneapolis, University of Minnesota Press, 2020, pp. 265, \$31.66 CAD, ISBN: 9781517909239

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To cite this article: Benjamin Faveri (2021) *Digitize and Punish: racial criminalization in the digital age*, Policing and Society, 31:3, 369-371, DOI: [10.1080/10439463.2021.1907385](https://doi.org/10.1080/10439463.2021.1907385)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/10439463.2021.1907385>



Published online: 02 Apr 2021.



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BOOK REVIEW

Digitize and Punish: racial criminalization in the digital age, Brian Jefferson,
Minneapolis, University of Minnesota Press, 2020, pp. 265, \$31.66 CAD, ISBN:
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With several recent predictive policing misuse cases and Canada and the US's federal government's call for further police technology adoption, Jefferson's *Digitize and Punish* provides a timely historical account of police technology's proliferation from the late 1800s to the present day and its negative racial and carceral implications within the US criminal justice system. *Digitize and Punish* fits nicely within the current policing and data literature, situating itself alongside Ferguson's (2017) *The Rise of Big Data Policing*, Fan's (2019) *Camera Power*, White and Malm's (2020) *Cops, Cameras, and Crisis*, and Brayne's (2020) *Predict and Surveil*. Each of these books offers a different perspective on police technology's proliferation. This book review provides: (1) the author's affiliation and authority; (2) the book's purpose; (3) the book's central argument; (4) the author's perspective; and (5) the intended audience.

1. Jefferson's affiliation and authority

Brian Jefferson is an associate professor of Geography and Geographic Information Sciences at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign. He holds degrees from the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign (BA), University of Westminster (MA), and the New School for Social Research (Ph.D.). His work broadly explores how digital technology, policing, race, and political economy connects to US urban contexts and carcerality. Recently, Jefferson's work has appeared in *Urban Geography*, *Environment and Planning A*, and *Annals of the American Association of Geographers*. This work largely examines digital technology application within New York and Chicago's criminal justice systems, the main cities discussed throughout his book. The information contained within *Digitize and Punish* has been collected and distilled over several years, beginning during Jefferson's Ph.D. and has appeared in several of his publications.

2. Books purpose

Digitize and Punish is written to 'clarify the historical significance behind the criminal justice data explosion' (p. 10). This book provides a historical timeline of numerous events spanning roughly 150 years, leading the reader from the first tabulation machine to current predictive policing and surveillance challenges. Jefferson uses an intersectional approach between these two events to examine racism, information technology capital, and carceral power. This intersectional approach offers readers a detailed account of several mischaracterised, misunderstood, and misleading arguments frequently used to support various criminal justice data collection techniques, task force creations, and police practices. Each detailed account helps the reader understand the historical significance of the criminal justice data explosion and contributes to this book's central argument.

3. Central argument

Digitize and Punish argues that the last 150 years of criminal justice data collection and usage has – and continues to – contribute to mass racial and carceral spaces. Each chapter provides a piece of Jefferson's argument. *Digitize and Punish* begins with the criminal justice system and policing's

technology integration history from the first tabulation machines to fingerprint collection and analysis. This history is provided alongside the developing sociological, criminological, and political science academic literature around these technologies and their implications, proponents, and opponents. Some of these literatures discuss the criminal justice system's data collection and analysis technologies and how they do not have or follow established standards for data collection, analysis, and use. This chapter concludes by acknowledging the emerging computational criminology field and its increased use in police services, bringing attention to predictive and hot spot policing and increased surveillance practices. The second piece of Jefferson's argument focuses on the US's prison system history and carceral implications from the criminal justice system's technology adoption. This argument piece focuses on digital data collection, database creation and management, and analytic software use within police precincts, prisons, and courthouses. The third piece of Jefferson's argument summarises the mischaracterised and misunderstood arguments used to support predictive policing. This summary examines predictive policing's shortcomings and current racial and carceral implications. Following this examination, Jefferson discusses how punishment and wireless technology are connected and how it allows citizens to monitor and sanction current and past offenders. Jefferson's final argument piece examines the union between smart cities and criminal justice through the proliferation of body-worn and smart cameras, sensors, and alarm systems. These devices collect several data types that are sent to crime data centres for analysis. Jefferson's conclusion explains how these data centres contribute to shifting geographies of carceral power.

4. Jefferson's perspective

Jefferson is against criminal justice's rapid data collection technology adoption and increased use in police precincts, prisons, and courthouses. Of the four other police and data books mentioned above, this is the only book that takes such a strong stance against these technologies. While some will disagree with this strong stance, this book and perspective are a useful contribution to the literature with its extensive research and historical accounts. Jefferson mentions he is unsure of how, or if, these technologies will continue as they have recently experienced several challenges like Palantir's recent initial public offering and its following public scrutiny; Axon's facial recognition software removal and vow not to use it unless technical standards are created and public demand increases; and Clearview AI's facial recognition software discontinuance after public outrage over its secretive use.

5. Intended audience

Digitize and Punish is best suited for academics familiar with the subject matter. Those familiar with the subject matter will greatly benefit from this book's extensive historical presentation from the late 1800s to present-day data use and its ongoing racial implications. Unfortunately, this book suffers, like other academic writing, from heavy jargon use and overly complicated prose; I found myself re-reading and looking up countless words, phrases, and ideas to understand this book's content correctly. While this type of writing is not necessarily bad, it does make it difficult for students, policymakers, and the public who are likely less familiar with the subject matter to benefit from this book's extensive research and historical accounts. However, as a second-year master's student studying police body-worn camera data governance policy, this book provided some much-needed historical context to my work.

6. Conclusion

Jefferson draws from several years of research to present a detailed historical account spanning roughly 150 years within *Digitize and Punish*. *Digitize and Punish* was written to provide the historical significance of the criminal justice data explosion and its racial and carceral implications. To make

this argument, Jefferson uses each chapter to build on the prior, leading the reader from the late 1800s to the present day, providing extensive detail throughout these chapters. *Digitize and Punish* moves from IBMs first tabulation machines to fingerprint collection to government crime database creation to early predictive and hot spot policing forms to current crime data centre analysis and the racial and carceral implications at each step.

I purposefully read this book, knowing it would ideologically conflict with my own and several works used within my own research. I hoped that this ideological conflict would force me to rethink some of my arguments – and that is exactly what happened. *Digitize and Punish* provided me with several counterarguments, strengthening my understanding of policing and data.

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<https://doi.org/10.1080/10439463.2021.1907385>

